

Figure 5: Configuring and setting up email

Figure 6: Creating a group mail account

Understanding users and user types

SugarCRM offers four types of users:

- **End User:** Can access/read/use modules, but has no administrative privileges
- **Administrator:** Has administrative privileges
- **Group User:** This is not a real user, but instead a user group to collect inbound mail. As such, group users, though listed under 'users', cannot even log in to SugarCRM. For example, you can create a 'Holiday' group that collects inbound mail for holiday-related issues.
- **Portal API User:** Can access/use portal Web services, but cannot log in to the SugarCRM Web interface.

To create new users, log in with administrative privileges. In the upper right hand corner of the admin interface, click 'Admin' to get the Administration screen, where you need to select 'User Management'. Under this section, you can view, modify and delete existing users, and create new ones. For instance, Figure 3 shows the page to create a new user. Along

similar lines, you can edit/modify existing user accounts too.

Setting up e-mail functionality

SugarCRM supports two types of outbound email accounts—system and personal. Bear in mind that there can be only one system outbound mail account. Almost all email-related tasks can be accomplished under *Admin->Email Settings*. You can configure email settings for campaigns, view the outbound mail queue, set up group accounts for inbound mail, and perform other related tasks. SugarCRM comes with native support for Gmail, Yahoo Mail, and Microsoft

Exchange. If you use any other mail provider, you can always customise the SMTP settings, if needed.

When it comes to inbound mail, you can choose to use personal or group email accounts. The former is used for individual access, whereas the latter is ideal for collaboration. If you wish to create a Group Mail account, you will be required to enter information about your mail server, as well as folders that are to be monitored. Furthermore, you need to manually specify most of the email-handling options.

However, SugarCRM does come with a one-click solution to load Gmail defaults for inbound email accounts.

Final words

We have seen that SugarCRM comes loaded with all the features of its proprietary competitors, and with the added goodness of FOSS! The final question is: *is it worth it?* Well, if you are looking for an open source, cloud-based CRM solution for your organisation, it surely is! Commercial use of SugarCRM is way cheaper than closed-sourced options, and this further cements its position as a viable CRM solution.

On the downside, if you do not need the added features of SugarCRM, you will have to customise the software yourself—the company itself offers only one solution, though the packages are different (in terms of space on the cloud, support options, etc). This can indeed be a deterrent for SMEs considering SugarCRM. However, this is a one-time effort, and once you set up SugarCRM, it operates hassle-free. All in all, SugarCRM definitely is an option to consider when looking for open source cloud-based CRMs. **END** 

References

SugarCRM Open Source Community: <http://goo.gl/gt2Nv>
 SugarCRM Developer Blog: <http://developers.sugarcrm.com/>

By: Sufyan bin Uzayr

The author is a freelance writer, graphics/Web designer, programmer and photographer. His prime areas of interest include FOSS, Web/mobile development, Web CMSs and vector art. He is also the editor of an e-journal named Brave New World (www.bravenewworld.in). You can visit his website at www.sufyan.co.nr or find him on Facebook at <http://facebook.com/sufyanism>.